Planning a national parks road trip

Pick three or four parks that sit within a day's drive of each other rather than trying to cross the whole country. Many popular parks need timed entry or campsite reservations months ahead, so book those first and fit the route around them.

Plan no more than four hours of driving on most days, and keep one flexible day for weather. Mountain roads can close in early spring and late autumn, so check the park's alerts a week before you leave.

Pack layers, a paper map for places without signal, plenty of water, and a cooler. An annual park pass pays for itself after three or four visits.